

Circa 350 BCE. Aristotle’s History of Animals groups living things based on their species, in a scala naturae that places organisms into 11 grades.

1665 CE. Micrographia, the richly illustrated book by Robert Hooke, reveals microscopic structures to a wider audience.

1758. The 10th edition of Systema Naturae by Carl Linnaeus classifies a range of plant and animal species using his binomial system.

1881. The Natural History Museum in London opens its doors to the public, free of charge. It now houses 80 million specimens.

1942. Ernst Mayr develops the biological species concept, which categorises species based on their ability to breed with each other.